

SOCCER DELIGHTS
(Clockwise from left) Football-shaped flags of countries that have qualified for the World Cup, in Doha; Al Bayt stadium, Doha; the Fifa World Cup poster at Hamad International Airport, Doha

I think I deserve a World Cup."

The enthusiasm in Tayeng's voice is both infectious and justified. Few events on the sporting calendar evoke the kind of global frenzy that the football World Cup does. "It was just street events and parties every day," says Ankit Sobti, 34, who went to Brazil for the 2014 World Cup and watched a couple of games in Salvador. "Being inside a city where matches were happening meant you'd have a different group of people coming in and spending time there; the whole diaspora would change. It was fascinating." Sobti, a tech professional in the US, was based in Mumbai at the time. He remembers finding the cheapest ticket to Brazil.

For all the cheer it affords, Fifa is no stranger to controversy. The bidding process for this year's World Cup and the treatment of migrant workers in Qatar have been subjects of much scrutiny. Also, for the first time in its history, the Fifa World Cup will be held in the winter months of November and December. This has provoked some ill-advised hostility in Europe, as it'll disrupt the league seasons there. None of this noise, though, has impacted the excitement of fans, which is slowly inching to its peak.

Given the conditions, the investment, the state-of-the-art facilities, it seems certain that the Qatar World Cup will be altogether unique. The stadiums have been fitted with giant air-conditioning systems to counter the high temperatures in the region. "The technology itself," says Tayeng, "is so fascinating. This is not just another World Cup." Moreover, as a way to accommodate more fans, "match day shuttles" will allow travellers to stay in neighbouring regions like Dubai and Muscat and fly into Qatar for the games. For Indians interested in attending the tournament, 'MATCH Hospitality', a Fifa-authorised global company, has also appointed Fanatic Sports and Cutting Edge as exclusive sales agents in India for the World Cup's official hospitality programme.

Nikhil Basu, 58, a company executive now based in the US, has booked tickets for Qatar with his two sons, aged 29 and 25, to watch two round-of-16 games, via a Qatar Airlines package (starting from $3,800). His sons follow the England team, while Basu supports Argentina—"I'm married to an Argentine, so for once we weren't fighting!" he says. While there was little exposure to football when he was growing up in the '70s—"You barely had TV in those days; nothing was televised"—he's been an Arsenal fan since the age of five, having lived in Britain briefly.

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"The logistics will be fantastic," says Basu. "It won't be like the horror stories you hear—the Euro '20 final [held last year; marred by hooliganism] or the recent UEFA Champions League final [where French police are alleged to have used unnecessary and excessive force against Liverpool fans outside the stadium]. It's such a showcase for Qatar; I think it's going to be an incredible operation. Everything should be super-efficient."

Varun Khullar, a 35-year-old adman based in Delhi and Mumbai, is also hopeful of getting tickets through a client company that is a co-sponsor of the World Cup. He's unsure of his plans, with no official word yet, but is excited about the possibility of going. He feels a lot of fans from India would end up going more for the football than the 'experience' of being in a World Cup country. Khullar recalls wanting to visit Brazil, "the game's spiritual home", in 2014 but couldn't at the time.

Rahul (name changed upon request), 30, a serving government official, visited five cities in Russia for the 2018 World Cup, and watched three matches in the group stages, along with a friend. Originally from Bengaluru, Rahul speaks of how Russia was a "melting pot", with people from all over the world—fans of the participating countries, travellers, locals. "I remember meeting a couple of people there who were telling me about Anup Jalota and *Seeta aur Geeta*!" he laughs.

For Qatar, the laws of the country